
434. Cf. pp. 431-36). It was only after 1765 that scholars started to question the reading of A (through fading and wear the middle line of the *theta* is no longer discernible).

H.C. Hoskier devotes Appendix J of *A Full Account and Collation of the Greek Codex Evangelium 604* (London: David Nutt, 1890) (the appendix being a reprint of part of an article that appeared in the *Clergyman's Magazine* for February 1887) to a careful discussion of the reading of Codex C. He spent three hours examining the passage in question in this MS (the MS itself) and adduces evidence that shows clearly, I believe, that the original reading of C is “God”. He examined the surrounding context and observes, “The **contracting-bar** has often vanished completely (I believe, from a cursory examination, more often than not), but at other times it is plain and imposed in the same way as at 1 Timothy iii.16” (Appendix J, p. 2). See also Burgon, *Ibid.*, pp. 437-38.

Codices F/G read *OC* wherein the contracting-bar is a slanting stroke. It has been argued that the stroke represents the aspirate of *oc*, but Burgon demonstrates that the stroke in question never represents breathing but is invariably the sign of contraction and affirms that “*oc* is **nowhere** else written *OC* [with a cross-bar] in either codex” (*Ibid.*, p. 442. Cf. pp. 438-42). Presumably the cross-line in the common parent had become too faint to see. As for cursive 365, Burgon conducted an exhaustive search for it. He not only failed to find it but could find no evidence that it had ever existed (*Ibid.*, pp. 444-45) [I have recently been informed that it was later rediscovered by Gregory].

(I took up the case of 1 Timothy 3:16, in the first edition of my book, *Identity*, solely to illustrate the argument from probability, not as an example of “how to do textual criticism” [cf. Fee, “A Critique”, p. 423]. Since the question has been raised, I will add a few words on that subject.)

The three significant variants involved are represented in the ancient uncial MSS as follows: O, OC, and ΘC (with a contracting-bar above the two letters), meaning “which”, “who”, and “God” respectively. In writing “God” a scribe’s omitting of the two lines (through haste or momentary distraction) would result in “who”. Codices A, C, F, and G have numerous instances where either the cross-line or the contracting-bar is no longer discernible (either the original line has faded to the point of being invisible or the scribe may have failed to write it in the first place). For both lines to fade away, as in Codex A here, is presumably an infrequent event. For a scribe to inadvertently omit both lines would presumably also be an infrequent event, but it must have happened at least once, probably early in the second century and in circumstances that produced a wide ranging effect.

The collocation “the mystery... who” is even more pathologic in Greek than it is in English. It was thus inevitable, once such a reading came into existence and became known, that remedial action would be attempted. Accordingly, the first reading above, “the mystery... which”, is generally regarded as an attempt to make the difficult reading intelligible. But it must have been an early development, for it completely dominates the Latin tradition, both version and Fathers, as well as being the probable reading of the Syr^p and Coptic versions. It is found in only one Greek MS, Codex D, and in no Greek Father before the fifth century.

Most modern scholars regard “God” as a separate therapeutic response to the difficult reading. Although it dominates the Greek MSS (over 98 percent), it is certainly attested by only two versions, the Georgian and Slavonic (both late). But it also dominates the Greek Fathers. Around AD 100 there are possible allusions in Barnabas, “*Ἰησοῦς ... ο υἱος του Θεου τυπω και εν σαρκι φανερωθεις*” (Cap. xii), and in Ignatius, “*Θεου ανθρωπων φανερουμενου*” (*Ad Ephes.* c. 19) and “*εν σαρκι γενομενος Θεος*” (*Ibid.*, c. 7). In the